

THE VISIONARY

From developing indigenous missile capability to motivating school children, the first scientist to become President of India is a role model for the nation's 600 million young people

■ By Arun Tiwari

Born on Rameswaram island in a Tamil-Muslim family, A.P.J. Abdul Kalam has covered a great distance to become the 11th President of the Indian Republic. He left the security of his family at the age of 10 as there was no high school on the island. He stopped eating non-vegetarian food at the age of 15 when he found the school mess bill unaffordable. He studied B.Sc. as there was no one to guide him on how to get in to engineering after his intermediate examination. He became an aeronautical engineer in the pursuit of his passion of flying an aircraft. Rejected by the Indian Air Force for a pilot's job, he continued to remain close to flying machines in the defence aeronautical establishment. Till this point, his life had been like that of any other small-town-lower-middle class Indian youth.

The first turning point came when the National Committee for Space Research (INSCOPAR) was formed in the early '60s and a talent pool of good aeronautical engineers was created to set up what later became the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). Kalam got an exposure to a purposeful life when he was sent to the US for a short training programme and was blessed with great teachers: Vikram Sarabhai and Satish Dhawan. He was chosen to lead the Satellite Launch Vehicle (SLV) project amongst many more distinguished peers. A decade of hard work saw India moving into suc-

cessful space research with the launch of SLV-3 in 1980. This experience shaped him into a formidable leader. He was decorated with the Padma Bhushan in 1981 and was given the task of developing indigenous missile capabilities. The '80s witnessed massive recruitment of hundreds of young engineers from campuses, grooming them into missile scientists.

Academic institutes and private industry became partners in defence projects. He was decorated in 1990 with the Padma Vibhushan and rose to become the chief of Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) in 1992. He then dreamt of civilian spin-offs of defence technology to benefit the common man with huge public investments and articulated the vision of a developed India by 2020—of a nation that is one of the best places to live in, through creative and effective leadership in Parliament, assemblies and other institutions of the state.

Kalam was responsible for freeing the Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) project from the indecision of choosing technology partners. He received the Bharat Ratna in 1997. He oversaw the nuclear tests and was later appointed principal scientific advisor to the government with a cabinet rank. He retired on his 71st birthday and went to the Anna University to teach technology and societal transformation. Till this point his life had been an example of the success of a hard working, upright scientific leader and administrator.

The second turning point in his life came in 2002 when he was approached by the ruling NDA Government to be its presidential candidate. For whatever reason the offer was made, it took the nation by storm and public jubilation marked his ascent to the highest office in the country. He used his years in the Rashtrapati Bhavan to travel extensively and connect with children who he saw as the citizens of a developed India.

Kalam's autobiography *Wings of Fire* became an all-time bestseller and found its place in school books and university curriculum. He remains simple, a teetotaler, vegetarian and celibate without any personal property or possessions. In him, 600 million youth of India see inspiration as well as aspiration. His recent book *You are Born to Blossom* says just that. And he remains humble to the core. At a book launch by a top BJP leader in Delhi, the former President was caught in a traffic snarl near the venue. He got out of his car and walked to the event accompanied by his security staff.

Kalam imbibes the simplicity of Mahatma Gandhi in his personal life and considers Caliph Omar as a model ruler. He still remains unaffected and unstained by the temptations and privileges that the world has offered him. He was, and remains, a traveller of life.

The writer co-authored Wings of Fire with Kalam